



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When a grown-up cans tomatoes, why do they add bottled lemon juice or something called citric acid?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To keep the tomatoes safe by making them a little more sour.

FUN FACT

Adding a bit of lemon juice helps stop bad germs from growing in the canned tomatoes!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When helping an adult can tomatoes, what do they do to the tomatoes first to make it easier to take off the skins?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

They put the tomatoes in warm water for a short time until the skins start to loosen.

FUN FACT

Warm water helps the tomato skins come off easily, almost like magic!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When making salsa for canning, why is it important not to change the ingredient amounts in tested recipes?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because changing ingredients can make the salsa unsafe to store.

FUN FACT

Food safety depends on the right recipe, not just taste!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What should you wear when handling hot peppers for salsa canning?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Plastic or rubber gloves.

FUN FACT

Hot pepper oils can sting your skin or eyes, so gloves are super helpful!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What happens if you don't add acid like lemon juice when canning tomatoes?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

The canned tomatoes might not be safe to eat because of low acidity.

FUN FACT

Acid helps keep canned tomatoes safe by stopping harmful bacteria.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When a grown-up makes spaghetti sauce to put in jars, why do they cook the chopped tomatoes for a while before sealing the jars?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Cooking the tomatoes helps make the sauce thicker and safer to store.

FUN FACT

Cooking the tomatoes helps get rid of tiny germs and makes the sauce thicker so it tastes yummy when you open the jar later!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When a grown-up fills jars with tomatoes to save them for later, why do they leave a little space (about half an inch to one inch) at the top of the jar before sealing it?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because the tomatoes need room to grow a bit when they get heated, and this helps the jar close tightly.

FUN FACT

The small space at the top of the jar lets the tomatoes expand during heating and helps the jar seal well, so the food stays fresh!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When a grown-up is helping to can tomatoes or salsas at home, what kind of water heater do they use to make sure the food stays safe to eat?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

They use a special pot called a boiling water canner or a pressure canner.

FUN FACT

A boiling water canner uses very hot steam to help keep canned food safe!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Why should you avoid using overripe or frost-damaged tomatoes for canning?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because they can make canned food unsafe or low quality.

FUN FACT

Fresh, healthy tomatoes make the safest and best-tasting canned foods!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When watching a grown-up preserve salsa in jars, about how many minutes does the salsa need to be heated in hot water to keep it safe and fresh?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

About 15 minutes

FUN FACT

Heating salsa for the right amount of time helps stop germs that can spoil the food, so it stays tasty and safe to eat!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What should you do if you don't wear gloves when chopping hot peppers for salsa?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Wash your hands with soap and water before touching your face.

FUN FACT

Pepper oils can sting your eyes and skin, so washing hands is super important!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

Why do you simmer salsa after mixing all ingredients before canning?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To blend flavors and help the salsa thicken.

FUN FACT

Simmering makes salsa taste yummier and safe for canning!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What is the most important reason to use tested recipes for canning salsas?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

They ensure the salsa is safe by having the right acidity and processing time.

FUN FACT

Never guess with canning recipes-tested ones keep your food safe!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When helping an adult can tomatoes, why do they warm up the tomato juice before putting it in the jars with the tomatoes?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Warming the juice helps make a good seal so the jars stay safe.

FUN FACT

Warming the juice before packing helps the jar seal properly, keeping the tomatoes fresh and safe to eat!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When you watch an adult canning tomatoes or salsa, why do they wipe the tops of the jars before putting on the lids?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

To make sure no food bits stop the jar from closing tightly.

FUN FACT

Wiping the jar tops helps them seal really well, so the food inside stays fresh and safe to eat!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

When a grown-up is getting tomatoes ready for canning, how long do they usually keep the tomatoes in hot water to make the skins easier to peel?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

About 30 to 60 seconds, or until the skins start to split

FUN FACT

A quick dip in hot water helps the tomato skins peel off super easily!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

If you watch a grown-up can tomatoes or salsa in a high place like on a mountain, what do they need to do when they heat the jars?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

They heat the jars for a longer time or use more heat to keep the food safe.

FUN FACT

At high places like mountains, water boils at a lower temperature, so grown-ups heat jars longer to make sure the food stays safe!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

What type of tomatoes can you use for canning according to the safety guide?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Any variety including heirloom or green tomatoes.

FUN FACT

You can use almost any tomato to make your own canned food at home!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Q

When helping a grown-up make salsa, how do they get the skins off chile peppers safely?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

They roast the peppers until the skins get bumpy, then cover them with a damp cloth to loosen the skins.

FUN FACT

Roasting chile peppers makes their skins easier to peel, which helps make salsa taste even better!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables



Tweens (10–14)

Q

Why do salsa recipes usually include bottled lemon or lime juice instead of fresh juice?



Tweens (10–14)

ANSWER

Because bottled juice has a consistent acidity for safety.

FUN FACT

Using bottled juices helps keep your canned salsa safe and yummy!

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables